



INTERNATIONAL ATOMIC ENERGY AGENCY (IAEA)

Background Paper

Topic: Strengthening Nuclear Non-Proliferation and Safeguards Amid Rising Geopolitical Tensions

Chair: _____

Moderator: _____

I. The International Atomic Energy Agency (IAEA): History and Powers

The International Atomic Energy Agency (IAEA) was established in 1957 as an autonomous international organization within the United Nations system. It was created in response to growing global concerns regarding the peaceful use of nuclear energy and the prevention of nuclear weapons proliferation.

Historical Background

The IAEA was founded following U.S. President Dwight D. Eisenhower's 1953 "Atoms for Peace" proposal, which aimed to promote peaceful nuclear cooperation while preventing the spread of nuclear weapons.

The Agency operates under three central pillars:

- Nuclear safety and security
- Nuclear safeguards and verification
- Promotion of peaceful uses of nuclear technology

Over the decades, the IAEA has played a critical role in verifying compliance with international nuclear agreements and supporting the global non-proliferation regime.

Powers and Functions

The IAEA has the authority to:

- Monitor and verify nuclear programs through inspections
- Implement safeguards agreements with Member States
- Report non-compliance to the UN Security Council
- Provide technical assistance for peaceful nuclear applications
- Promote nuclear safety standards

While the IAEA cannot enforce military action, its inspection reports and findings significantly influence international diplomatic and security decisions.

II. Introduction to the Topic

Nuclear non-proliferation remains a cornerstone of global security. However, rising geopolitical tensions, modernization of nuclear arsenals, regional conflicts, and technological advancements have increased concerns regarding the effectiveness of existing safeguards.

Strengthening nuclear non-proliferation mechanisms is essential to prevent the spread of nuclear weapons, reduce the risk of nuclear conflict, and maintain international stability.

III. Historical and Strategic Background

The global non-proliferation regime is largely built around the Treaty on the Non-Proliferation of Nuclear Weapons (NPT), which entered into force in 1970. The NPT aims to:

- Prevent the spread of nuclear weapons
- Promote peaceful nuclear cooperation
- Encourage nuclear disarmament

The IAEA serves as the verification body for the NPT, conducting inspections to ensure that civilian nuclear programs are not diverted toward military purposes.

Additional safeguards tools include:

- Comprehensive Safeguards Agreements
- The Additional Protocol
- Nuclear export control regimes

Despite these mechanisms, geopolitical rivalries and regional security concerns continue to challenge the non-proliferation framework.

IV. Security and Global Implications

Weakening safeguards and proliferation risks may lead to:

1. Regional Arms Races

States may pursue nuclear capabilities in response to perceived security threats.

2. Undermining International Trust

Non-compliance with safeguards erodes confidence in multilateral agreements.

3. Increased Risk of Nuclear Conflict

Escalating tensions between nuclear-armed states heighten global instability.

4. Nuclear Security Threats

The risk of nuclear material falling into non-state actors' hands remains a concern.

5. Challenges of Emerging Technologies

Advancements in nuclear technology and cyber capabilities complicate monitoring and verification efforts.

V. International Framework

Key international frameworks include:

- Treaty on the Non-Proliferation of Nuclear Weapons (NPT)
- IAEA Safeguards Agreements
- The Additional Protocol
- Comprehensive Nuclear-Test-Ban Treaty (CTBT)
- UN Security Council resolutions on non-proliferation

While these agreements provide a structured system, compliance and enforcement depend heavily on political will and international cooperation.

VI. Current Situation (2026 Context)

As of 2026:

- Geopolitical tensions between major powers remain high.
- Some states continue expanding or modernizing nuclear arsenals.
- Concerns persist regarding transparency and compliance in certain nuclear programs.

- Cybersecurity threats pose new risks to nuclear facilities.
- Discussions continue on strengthening safeguards and verification mechanisms.

The effectiveness of the global non-proliferation regime depends on maintaining trust, transparency, and cooperation among Member States.

VII. Key Questions for Debate

Delegates should consider:

- How can the IAEA strengthen its safeguards system amid geopolitical tensions?
- Should the Additional Protocol become mandatory for all Member States?
- How can verification mechanisms adapt to emerging technologies?
- What measures can prevent nuclear material from reaching non-state actors?
- How can diplomatic cooperation be strengthened to reduce nuclear risks?

VIII. Conclusion

Strengthening nuclear non-proliferation and safeguards is essential to maintaining global peace and security.

The IAEA plays a central role in:

- Monitoring nuclear activities
- Ensuring compliance with international agreements
- Promoting peaceful nuclear cooperation
- Reducing global nuclear risks

Delegates must develop strategies that reinforce transparency, trust, and multilateral cooperation in an increasingly tense geopolitical environment.